

MANDAR DEODHAR

UDITI MITTLE, 21 ▲

Founder, Chic Stationery, Mumbai

Mittle was barely 13 when she started personalising her notebooks and designing weekly planners. "As a young child obsessed with building my inventory of stationery at home, I was perpetually disappointed with boring colours and covers of the notebooks that I used in school," she says. Pushed by her mother, who is herself a jewellery designer and entrepreneur, Mittle started making personalised stationery for family and friends under her brand Chic Stationery, where "every item is designed keeping creativity and luxury in mind". She completed her graduation last year, and, unlike most of her peers, decided not to go for campus placements, preferring to look after her business. However, she doesn't reject the idea of taking up a job. "There are many traits that corporate jobs instil in you, such as discipline, accountability, adjustability and compromise. Whilst being your own boss does permit a more flexible routine, working a corporate job involves mastering core lessons like teamwork, which would otherwise not be deemed necessary," she says.



"IN INDIA, 88 PER CENT GEN Zers PREFER FIRMS THAT WALK THE TALK WHEN IT COMES TO DIVERSITY AND SUSTAINABILITY"

SUSAN MATHEW
HR Director, LinkedIn India

the new generation.

Nagina Singh, senior director & people lead, of F&B company Mondelez India, points out a caveat, though. "Gen Zers prefer digital platforms for communication over in-person discussions, which might impact their ability to navigate various situations at a workplace," she says. "That, in turn, takes away the understanding of how interpersonal skills can be a game changer in certain situations. Occasionally, their resilience in various situations could be limited and, hence, there is a need for regular mentoring support and guidance." Many HR experts also feel that investing in training Gen Zers can be a risky bet, given their short tenures, which, in turn, also renders them unsuitable for long-term projects. "Managers are constantly on their toes as Gen Zers seek higher attention/ recognition to keep themselves fulfilled. The entitled mindset they tend to come to work with makes the manager's job harder. Organisations need to keep reinventing and investing more in engaging them, which can be challenging," says Karanth.

Doctors, too, call attention to this. "What this group doesn't understand is that solutions require resilience, patience and adaptability," says Delhi-based psychiatrist Dr Sameer Malhotra. "They want instant answers. This is usually a result of the instant gratification they receive through the internet. Learning to wait is a skill they need to acquire."

Companies are trying to overcome other challenges as well. Flexibility is high on Gen Z's list, and thus bringing them back to office after the Covid-19 pandemic, to simply clock hours, has been a mammoth task. In RPG Group's survey, for instance, nearly 64 per cent Gen Zers said they wanted a flexible work environment. In Xpheno, these shifting dynamics meant going from a 40 per cent Gen Z workforce over a year earlier to 26 per cent in 2023. For other companies, it meant rethinking their policies. LinkedIn data for 2022 showed that on-site roles decreased by 10 per cent in India in that year, while hybrid work arrangements for entry-level positions increased by 60 per cent. "Today's pursuit for talent is as competitive as ever, driven by advancing technologies, generational shifts, and evolving dynamics around the nature of work. We have followed a very flexible approach